E-E-A-T checklist: 36 checks

Trust, authors, content, reputation and structured data. Every check has a priority, a way to verify it and a basis in Google's documentation. Version: November 2026.

Site (URL) _____ Review date _____

Reviewed by _____ Next review _____

> **Trust matters most.** Experience, expertise and authoritativeness support it, but content doesn't have to show all of them at once.
>
> **E-E-A-T itself isn't a specific ranking factor.** Google uses many signals; this list checks whether your site shows what a person deciding whether to trust you looks for.
>
> **Quality raters don't change rankings.** Their guidelines help you see your site through a reader's eyes.

How to use this template

1. **Pick the pages:** homepage, About, Contact, 3–5 service pages and your 10 pages with the most Google traffic.
2. **Do step 0** (below): decide whether your page topics are YMYL.
3. **Work through areas A–E** and mark every check OK, needs work or N/A.
4. **Research your reputation** with the searches in check D1 and record the results in the table on the last page.
5. **Describe the problem in the notes:** the URL and specifics, e.g. "/blog/vat-2026: no byline, rates without a source."
6. **Build the plan:** high priority first, and for YMYL content B6 and C2 first. Give each action an owner and a deadline.

Statuses and priorities

- ☐ **OK** – the check passes
- ☐ **Fix** – needs work: note the URL and the problem
- ☐ **N/A** – doesn't apply, leave it out of the score

HIGH failure undermines trust or breaks Google's rules; do it first

MEDIUM weakens how the site is assessed

LOW housekeeping

Step 0. Is the topic YMYL?

YMYL covers topics where mistakes could harm people's health, finances or safety, or society; most topics aren't YMYL. For each group of pages, answer the two questions from Google's rater guidelines (section 2.3). **YMYL types:** Health or safety · Financial security · Government, civics and society · Other topics that could hurt people.

1. Would a careful person seek out experts or highly trusted sources here, because even minor inaccuracies could cause harm? If yes, the topic is likely YMYL.
2. Would most people be content with casually asking their friends about it? If yes, the topic is likely not YMYL.

GROUP OF PAGES (URL OR SECTION)	QUESTION 1	QUESTION 2	IS THE TOPIC YMYL?	WHO WRITES AND WHO REVIEWS
	☐ yes ☐ no	☐ yes ☐ no	☐ clearly ☐ maybe ☐ no	
	☐ yes ☐ no	☐ yes ☐ no	☐ clearly ☐ maybe ☐ no	
	☐ yes ☐ no	☐ yes ☐ no	☐ clearly ☐ maybe ☐ no	

Clearly YMYL: checks B6 and C2 go to the top of the list. No expert review yet? Don't pretend there was one: say the page isn't professional advice and schedule the review.

A. Trust: who is behind the site

What the site says about itself: who is responsible for it, how to get in touch, whether selling is fair and safe, and whether claims are backed up. **8 checks**

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
A1	**The About page says who is responsible for the site: the full business or personal name, what you do, where you operate and who runs it** **How to check:** Read your About page as someone who has never heard of you. Within a minute they should know who is behind the content and the offer. Basis: Rater guidelines, 2.5.2	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A2	**Contact details are easy to find from every page: phone, email, address or service area, and company details** **How to check:** Check the footer and menu on the homepage, an article and a service page. A contact form alone isn't enough for services or sales. Basis: Rater guidelines, 2.5.3	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A3	**If the site takes orders or payments, the terms, payment, returns and complaints policies and customer service contact are public** **How to check:** Go through the order path to the end. Note where a customer finds this information before paying. No online sales: N/A. Basis: Rater guidelines, 2.5.3 and 3.4	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A4	**The site is safe: HTTPS with no browser warnings, no suspicious redirects, forced downloads or ads posing as content** **How to check:** Open a few pages in a private window and on a phone. Our free SEO audit also checks HTTPS and the http:// redirect. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.4 (safety)	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A5	**Claims about the business (number of clients, results, awards, certificates, "No. 1") are backed by a source, a date or a document** **How to check:** List every number and award on your homepage and About page. Note where the proof is for each. No proof: remove it or make it specific. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.1	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A6	**Reviews, testimonials and case studies on the site come from real customers and can be verified** **How to check:** Note the source of each testimonial: your Business Profile, an email, the client's consent. A link to your Google Business Profile lets readers see every review. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.2	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A7	**The offer says plainly what the customer gets: scope, price or how it's quoted, timing and how to cancel** **How to check:** Read a service page as a customer would. Do you know what you'll pay, or what the price depends on, and how to end the contract? Basis: Our practice	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
A8	**Your business name, address, phone number and description match on your site, your Google Business Profile and your other profiles** **How to check:** Copy the details from each place into one table and compare them character by character. The same check is in the SEO checklist (C4). Basis: Our practice	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

Area result: ☐ OK ____ ☐ needs work ____ ☐ N/A ____

B. Authors and experience: who created the content

Who wrote the content, whether they're a real person, whether they know the subject first-hand and whether a qualified person checked YMYL content. **8 checks**

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
B1	**Articles, guides and reviews carry an author byline wherever a reader might ask "who wrote this?"** **How to check:** Review your 10 pages with the most Google traffic. A service page can be credited to the company; an expert guide needs a named person. Basis: Google: helpful content ("Who")	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
B2	**The byline links to an author page: their role, what they do, what they write about, and contact details or a professional profile** **How to check:** Click the byline. If it isn't a link or leads to an empty page, the check fails. Basis: Google: helpful content ("Who")	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
B3	**The author is a real person: no made-up names, AI-generated headshots or credentials they don't hold** **How to check:** Compare the bio with the author's professional profile. Google calls fabricated author profiles a form of deception that makes a page untrustworthy. Basis: Google: helpful content ("Who")	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
B4	**The bio gives verifiable facts instead of filler: job title, scope of work, projects, and a registration number for a regulated profession** **How to check:** Underline every sentence in the bio that can't be checked ("passionate," "expert with years of experience"). Replace it with facts or cut it. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.4	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
B5	**The content shows first-hand experience: your own photos, screenshots, data, a description of a test or an example from real work** **How to check:** For each guide, note what in it is yours and missing from other results. If there's nothing, the page is summarizing others. Basis: Google: helpful content; guidelines, 3.4	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
B6	**YMYL content (health, finance, safety, civic matters) is written or reviewed by a qualified person, and the page shows who reviewed it and when** **How to check:** Do step 0 first. For a YMYL topic, add a line such as "Reviewed by [name], [profession], [date]" under the content. Not YMYL: N/A. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.4.1	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
B7	**If AI played a substantial part in creating the content and a reader might ask "how was this made?", the page explains it, and AI isn't credited as the author** **How to check:** Write down an editorial rule: who fact-checks AI-assisted content. Google says an AI author byline is probably not the best way to show it. Basis: Google: AI-generated content (FAQ)	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
B8	**The site sticks to its subjects: content covers what the business does and what its authors know** **How to check:** Group your articles by topic. Send anything outside your expertise, written only for search traffic, to review. Basis: Google: helpful content	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

Area result: ☐ OK ____ ☐ needs work ____ ☐ N/A ____

C. Content: accuracy, sources and freshness

Whether the content is accurate and sourced, whether dates tell the truth, whether the page adds something of its own and whether readers know how it was made. **8 checks**

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
C1	**Figures, regulations, recommendations and quotes have a source: a link to the original document, not to a summary** **How to check:** Highlight every number and every "according to…" in the text. Each needs a link or a named source with a date. Basis: Google: helpful content (expertise questions)	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
C2	**The content has no easily verified errors, and on YMYL topics it matches established expert consensus** **How to check:** Ask someone in your field who didn't write it to read it. Google itself suggests asking trusted people unaffiliated with your site. Basis: Google: helpful content (accuracy)	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
C3	**The page shows a publication or update date with a label ("Published," "Updated")** **How to check:** Check articles and pages with data that changes: prices, rules, rates. A date without a label is unclear. Basis: Google: byline dates	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
C4	**The update date only changes when the content changes substantially** **How to check:** Compare the "Updated" date with the revision history in your CMS. Google lists changing dates just to look fresh as a sign of search-engine-first content. Basis: Google: helpful content	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
C5	**The content adds something of its own: data, an example, analysis or lessons from practice, rather than rewriting other sources** **How to check:** Compare the page with the top three Google results. List what you have that they don't. An empty list fails the check. Basis: Google: helpful content (originality)	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
C6	**The title and H1 describe the content accurately: no exaggeration, shock value or promises the text doesn't keep** **How to check:** Read the title, then the text. Does the title promise something the page doesn't deliver? Basis: Google: helpful content	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
C7	**Where it matters, the content says how it was made: how you tested, how many things you checked, where the data comes from and what period it covers** **How to check:** Reviews, rankings, comparisons and data reports need a method section. A general how-to guide: often N/A. Basis: Google: helpful content ("How")	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
C8	**The writing is careful, with no typos or errors, and ads and pop-ups don't cover the main content** **How to check:** Read the page on a phone. Check that you can reach the content without closing windows. Basis: Google: helpful content; guidelines, 2.4	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

Area result: ☐ OK ____ ☐ needs work ____ ☐ N/A ____

D. Reputation: what others say about you

What independent sources say about the business and its authors, what reviews look like and whether recommendations on the site disclose conflicts of interest. **7 checks**

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
D1	**You know what others say about the business: results for [business name -site:yourdomain.com] and [business name reviews -site:yourdomain.com]** **How to check:** Run both searches in Google, go through the first two pages of results and record your findings in the reputation table on the last page of the template. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.3	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
D2	**Authors have a footprint too: publications, talks, a professional profile, an entry in a professional register** **How to check:** Search for [author name + topic]. If nothing comes up, start with a professional profile and link to it from the bio. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.4	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
D3	**Your Google Business Profile and review sites have recent reviews, and the business replies to them, critical ones included** **How to check:** Business Profile → Reviews. Reply factually and leave out customer details. A few negative reviews are normal; what they say matters. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.2	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
D4	**The business doesn't buy reviews, offer discounts or gifts for them, or post them from multiple accounts** **How to check:** Check how you ask for reviews: emails, flyers, discount codes. Google Maps policy bans paid and incentivized reviews. Basis: Google Maps content policy	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
D5	**Recurring complaints have been looked into and the cause fixed** **How to check:** Group critical reviews and mentions by topic. A problem that keeps coming back has to be solved in the business, not in the copy. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.2	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
D6	**Independent sources mention the business or its authors: trade media, organizations, directories, events** **How to check:** List mentions from the last 12 months. Sponsored articles and your own social media profiles are not independent sources. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.3.1	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
D7	**Recommendations, rankings and reviews disclose conflicts of interest: your own product, an affiliate link, paid partnerships** **How to check:** Check every page that recommends a product or company. The disclosure belongs next to the content, not only in your terms. Basis: Rater guidelines, 3.4	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

Area result: ☐ OK ____ ☐ needs work ____ ☐ N/A ____

E. Structured data: your business and authors described for Google

JSON-LD markup that helps Google connect content to your business and its authors. It should describe what's already visible on the page. **5 checks**

NO.	CHECK AND HOW TO VERIFY IT	PRIORITY	STATUS	NOTES · OWNER · DEADLINE
E1	**The homepage has Organization or LocalBusiness markup: name, logo, address, contact details and sameAs links to your business profiles** **How to check:** Use the Rich Results Test or the schema.org validator. Our free SEO audit checks whether this markup exists. Basis: Google: Organization structured data	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
E2	**Articles have Article markup in which each author has a separate author field with the Person type and a url or sameAs** **How to check:** Run the schema.org validator on one article. The name in the markup must match the byline. Basis: Google: Article structured data	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
E3	**The author page has ProfilePage markup with the author as its main subject (mainEntity)** **How to check:** Run the validator on the author page. With a single author, a Person node with a stable @id on the About page, referenced by your articles, is enough. Basis: Google: ProfilePage structured data	LOW	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
E4	**datePublished and dateModified in the markup match the dates visible on the page** **How to check:** Compare the JSON-LD with the date under the title. Dates must not be in the future. Basis: Google: byline dates	MEDIUM	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	
E5	**Structured data only describes what readers can see: no hidden authors, ratings or reviews** **How to check:** Compare every JSON-LD property with the page content. Google explicitly lists fake reviews in markup as not allowed. Basis: Google: general structured data guidelines	HIGH	☐ OK ☐ Fix ☐ N/A	

Area result: ☐ OK ____ ☐ needs work ____ ☐ N/A ____

Reputation research (checks D1–D6)

Run the searches in Google, go through the first two pages of results and record what you find. Count only sources independent of the business: media, organizations, review sites, forums. Skip your own profiles and sponsored articles.

SEARCH OR PLACE	SOURCE FOUND (URL)	TONE	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
[business name] -site:yourdomain.com		☐ + ☐ 0 ☐ –	
[business name] reviews -site:yourdomain.com		☐ + ☐ 0 ☐ –	
[author name] + topic		☐ + ☐ 0 ☐ –	
Google Business Profile: reviews and replies		☐ + ☐ 0 ☐ –	
Trade media, organizations and directories		☐ + ☐ 0 ☐ –	
		☐ + ☐ 0 ☐ –	

Action plan

Turn every “needs work” check into an action. High priority first; for YMYL content, B6 and C2 first. After the fix, recheck the item and update the summary below.

NO.	PAGE URL	ACTION	OWNER	DEADLINE	DONE
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐

Review summary

AREA	CHECKS	OK	NEEDS WORK	N/A	OPEN HIGH-PRIORITY CHECKS
A. Trust	8				
B. Authors and experience	8				
C. Content	8				
D. Reputation	7				
E. Structured data	5				
Total	**36**				